

Proof of Personhood

US – Northeast/NYC

The Premise

As influencers, algorithms, and an exponential increase of AI usage floods our digital spaces with unreliable, synthetic content, it has become **increasingly difficult to distinguish what is real** from what is not. Now, people are **seeking authentic experiences** marked with the human touch, indicated by imperfection and creativity. This trend is a pivot towards prioritizing more **physical presence and unfiltered moments** as we re-discover that that being messy, manual, and real serve as the ultimate proof that life is truly being lived.

Why is this important?

This is a continuation of a desire for transparency and authenticity, and a reassertion of human control amid growing automation. Being trendy on social media and digital platforms isn't disappearing; instead, it serves as springboards for exploring tangible, real-world experiences. People who discovered the same thing online then find each other in the real world and connect IRL. People shape their own experiences around what carries genuine personal significance.

What is the core conflict / opportunity?

The proposition of AI and related technologies has always been to solve problems and improve our QoL. Digital spaces continue to serve as connection points across cultures and communities, removing barriers.

However, even as AI improves in its capabilities, there is still a fundamental, deep-seeded deep distrust and rejection of AI that has not been resolved from the perspective of consumers.

These two tensions will continue to exist and is something that we need to navigate thoughtfully to keep consumer trust in the experiences we design. Leaning into human experience and being mindful of when we engage them and how we suggest utilizing AI can help us to walk this line with them.

Key statistics / quotes / evidence (from within your country)

- **Art and Human Craft:** [W/26-27 Catwalk Trends: Human Craft vs AI Fashion](#) [Boston Public Library launches printmaking workshops to foster community](#) [An artist spent a whole week bed-rotting in a public NYC gallery](#)
- **Community Organization:** [Duck libraries popping up in NYC are sparking a trend of joy for kids](#) [Literary events and pursuits have become very popular in NYC](#) [NYS Fair adds Shrek-themed dance party to 2026 concert lineup](#)
- **Human Connections:** [Boston is tackling the loneliness epidemic by helping people make friends](#) [Conversation and companionship fight loneliness for older New Yorkers](#) [Wrestling speed dating: A unique Valentine's Day in Brooklyn](#) [NYC singles ditch dating apps for new 'Love Is Blind' style IRL event](#) [This Somerville matchmaker has Boston's dating scene down to a science](#)
- **Protest and political engagement:** [Boston May Day protest: Live stream updates](#) [Eight companies explore dance as protest in 'The Politics of Movement'](#) [Ice national shutdown protests expected NYC](#) [Boston No Kings protest march](#)
- **AI Pushback:** [StopFriend Advocates, educators warn NYC students could be at risk under new AI school guidelines](#) [Brooklyn mental health leaders explore how AI is shaping loneliness](#) [New research shows consumers prefer a 'Human' AI persona](#)

Why did the studio pick this one?

This trend is likely not limited to NYC / Boston; however, we represent two very emotional and outspoken cities who don't hide their feelings and have active creative communities. Through local fashion, community events, outreach, protest and art, the sentiment of seeking authenticity and connection as part of a community is seen on the streets on a day-to-day basis and expressed openly, even without people necessarily realizing it.

In your roles within Song and DDP, how does it impact your work or your clients?

As designers and strategists, our work has always been to protect user autonomy and guiding our clients to do the same. Highlighting human craft and expertise that an algorithm can't replicate can help move a client's products beyond transparency to demonstrating sincerity that consumers will respond to. We should help our clients reinforce interactions that aren't just about transaction but meets the customer's emotional needs of security and reassurance to a meaningful relationship with their customers.